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BUSINESS CASE COMPETITION 2026

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Qualifying Round

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY:
Middle East SME Banking Digitization (B2B) First; GenAI & Stablecoins Later

Planto

CRITICAL RECOMMENDATION & RESOURCE ALLOCATION

We recommend Planto prioritize **"Middle East Small and Medium Enterprise Banking Digitization (Business-to-Business)"** as the singular core pivot. Expansion into high-growth curves—Generative Artificial Intelligence and Stablecoins—will follow only after the core business is ROI-proven and scalable.

NEXT PHASE FOCUS
B2B CORE FIRST

THE STRATEGIC RATIONALE (WHY MIDDLE EAST?)

R REGULATORY WINDOW

Open Finance Momentum

Regulatory sandbox / regulator-endorsed pathways (UAE/KSA) for third-party data sharing reduce cooperation friction, legitimizing Planto's proprietary technology as a vital Tier-1 bank partner.

D DEMAND WINDOW

High-Impact SME Needs

Regional SMEs lack sophisticated cash-flow forecasting and reconciliation automation, providing Planto a clear path to deliver measurable efficiency gains for banks.

C CAPABILITY WINDOW

Transferable Asset Stack

Planto's proven technology—built in Hong Kong—integrating institutions and generating insights is prepared for rapid localization into emerging open-finance markets.

18-MONTH EXECUTION COMMITMENT

MONTHS 0 - 6

Foundations & Pilots

- Secure 1–2 Tier-1 Anchor Bank Pilots
- Complete localized product scoping
- Establish formal regulatory sandbox pathway

MONTHS 6 - 12

Market Entry (MVP)

- Launch core Business-to-Business modules
- Close ROI loop: evidence of efficiency gains
- AI used only as a light enhancement

MONTHS 12 - 18

Standardized Scale

- Harden repeatable delivery / SOP template
- Publish joint success case with anchor bank
- Trigger: Phase 2 innovation curves

COMPANY ANALYSIS：CURRENT STATUS & TRIGGERS FOR CHANGE

Planto

Main Business

1 B2C subscriptions
- Aggregating data from 70+ institutions
- Accumulating foundational financial personas
- Targeting high-LTV heavy user segments

2 Affiliate/cross-selling
- Behavior-clustering driven cross-selling engine
- 40% lower CAC vs. industry benchmark
- High conversion rates & distribution efficiency

3 B2B SaaS/implementation fees
- Packaging & licensing AI insights and aggregation tech
- Charging upfront implementation and integration fees
- Securing high-proportion, high-margin Annual Recurring Revenue (ARR)

Growth Constraint in Hong Kong

Market Ceiling (Limited Scale)

Intensifying Competition (Differentiation Pressure)

Service-Heavy Growth Risk (Margin Pressure)

Triggers for Change

Scale Bottlenecks *(Local Market Ceiling)*
- Limited TAM (Total Addressable Market) in Hong Kong
- Current operations insufficient to drive the next exponential valuation leap

Technological Disruption *(The GenAI Wave)*
- GenAI reshaping the fundamental architecture of financial interactions
- Risk of obsolescence due to generational tech gaps

Regulatory Tailwinds *(Stablecoin Compliance)*
- Implementation of new stablecoin regulatory frameworks
- Blue ocean in digital asset aggregation and B2B settlement

Macro Catalyst *(Window for Global Expansion)*
- Emerging markets (e.g., Middle East) entering the Open Finance era
- Surge in essential SME digitalization demands

WHY NOW & WHY MIDDLE EAST?

A triple window of regulatory openness, urgent SME digital demand, and bank transformation investment creates the ideal launchpad for Planto.

Regulatory Window

- **Policy Openness:** The environment has ushered in unprecedented opportunities for open-finance strategies.
- **Data Sharing Mechanisms:** Third-party data sharing frameworks are being gradually and actively implemented.
- **Reduced Barriers:** Policy friction hindering cooperation between financial institutions and tech providers has significantly dropped.

Demand Window

- **Beyond Basic Payments:** What SMEs truely need: *cash flow forecasting, efficient administration, expense management, and automated accounting.*
- **Institutional Focus:** government support programs for SMEs (e.g. official UAE platforms)

> Planto has got 'Tools with built-in data tracking and performance measurement capabilities' which are demanded by SMEs

Capability Window

- **Validated Competencies:** Ability to reuse core modules validated in Hong Kong (mature data connection & aggregation).
- **Proven Engines:** Deployment of AI insights and highly efficient commerce distribution models.
- **Strict Compliance:** Rich operational experience navigating financial compliance and data security.

> Ready to reorganize capabilities to create customized product packages for local Middle Eastern needs.

SUCCESS CRITERIA FRAMEWORK

The same set of rigorous standards compares different strategic lines to ensure objective, ROI-driven decision-making.

Strategic Fit

- Fit with Planto's core competencies.
- Matching with the company's profitability DNA.
- Core competencies are transferable and reusable.

Market Attractiveness

- The intensity of demand and pain points in the target market.
- Market size and growth potential.
- Customers' willingness to pay and ability to pay.

Regulatory Feasibility

- The degree of openness and adaptability of local regulatory policies.
- The compliance path of business implementation is clear.
- Uncertainty and risk coefficient of regulatory policies.

Speed to Traction

- Complete the cycle of POC/pilot projects.
- Time efficiency for first revenue.
- The pace of promotion from pilot to large-scale.

Execution Complexity & Risk

- The technical difficulty of product landing and delivery.
- The size of the resource gap such as team and funds.
- The number and controllability of core risk points in the landing process.

STRATEGIC OPTIONS & QUANTIFIED SCORING

SCORE 5
Clear advantage: proven path, low risk, traction < 12 months.

SCORE 4
Strong: high confidence, manageable risk, clear ROI path.

SCORE 3
Neutral: feasible but needs significant validation or investment.

SCORE 2
Weak: meaningful gaps (partners, compliance, or GTM) to close.

SCORE 1
Low priority: strategic mismatch, heavy constraints, or high capex.

Quantitative Comparison

Evaluation Criteria	Option A: HK B2B Deepen	Option B: AI-First Pivot	Option C: Middle East SME B2B
Strategic Fit (DNA)	●●●●○	●●●○○	●●●●●
Market Attractiveness	●●○○○	●●●●○	●●●●●
Regulatory Feasibility	●●●●●	●●●○○	●●●●○
Speed to Traction	●●●●○	●●○○○	●●●○○
Execution Complexity & Risk	●●●●○	●●○○○	●●●○○
TOTAL STRATEGIC SCORE	**19 / 25**	**14 / 25**	**20 / 25**

1. Strategic Fit
Direct DNA Match
- Option A: 4 pt– fit with current B2B stack; minimal reinvention
- Option B: 3 pt– partial fit; may shift focus to R&D vs. bank ROI delivery
- Option C: 5 pt– direct reuse of aggregation/insights/compliance; same buyer (banks)

2. Market Attractiveness
High ROI Growth
- Option A: 2 pt— HK market ceiling limits incremental upside
- Option B: 4 pt— Strong AI tailwinds, but ROI/WTP still to prove
- Option C: 5 pt— Open-finance momentum + urgent SME digitization gap

3. Regulatory Feasibility
De-risked Path
- Option A: 5 pt— Highest certainty in current regulatory environment
- Option B: 3 pt— AI governance varies; approval path less standardized
- Option C: 4 pt— Feasible via sandbox + bank-led path; needs local hosting/audits

4. Speed to Traction
Pilot Velocity
- Option A: 4 pt— Fastest pilots via existing relationships
- Option B: 2 pt— "Demo fast, paid slow" risk; needs anchor customer
- Option C: 3 pt— Pilot-led entry; moderate speed to paid rollout

5. Execution Complexity & Risk
Mitigations Defined
- Option A: 4 pt— Low delivery risk; known integration playbook
- Option B: 2 pt— High uncertainty in GTM + monetization + scope creep
- Option C: 3 pt— Manageable with partners + phased rollout + milestone payments

Option A: HK B2B Deepen Pivot
High fit & speed with the strongest regulatory certainty.
However, incremental growth is constrained by a clear market ceiling.
High certainty / low upside.

Option B: AI-First Pivot
Technically feasible, but risks a long R&D cycle without a near-term anchor customer and ROI proof.
Harder to build a repeatable GTM motion quickly.

Option C: Middle East Expansion Pivot
Largest upside with strong capability match.
Risks are managed via sandbox pathway + anchor bank pilot + phased rollout.
Clear pilot→land→expand execution plan.

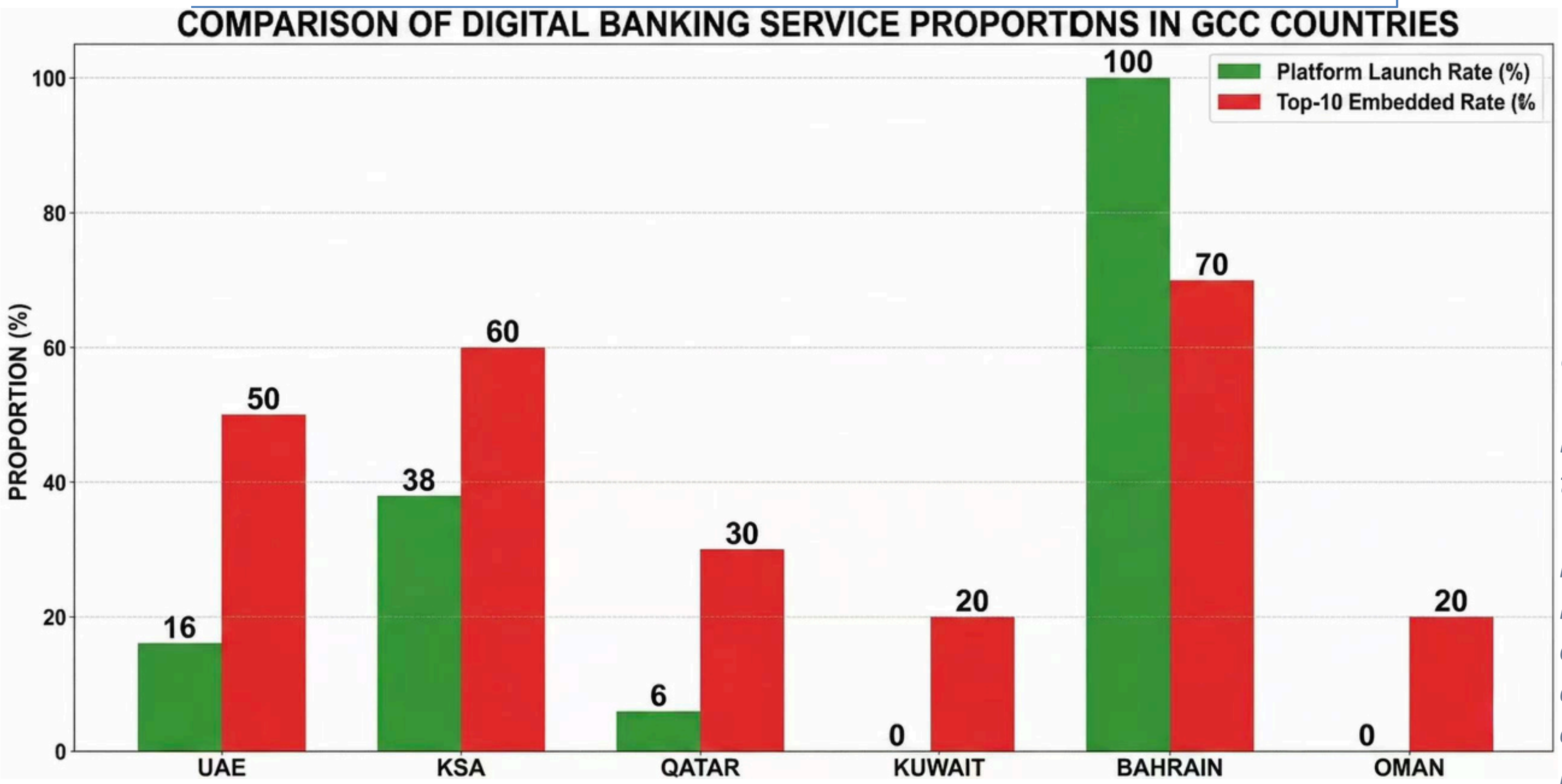
MARKET OVERVIEW & CUSTOMER PROFILING

The GCC exhibits fragmented digital maturity: UAE and KSA provide massive scale for SME monetization, while Bahrain serves as an optimal mature sandbox for API integration.In most regions, the bank account opening rate is less than 30%, which is an opportunity for the development of fintech companies.

(1) GCC Market Dynamics

Country	Banks	Total SMEs	Platform Live Rate
KSA	39	1,300,000+	38%
UAE	61	557,000	16%
Oman	17	141,126	0%
Bahrain	12	55,000	100%
Kuwait	23	50,000	0%
Qatar	16	32,000	6%

**Note: Platform live rates indicate the percentage of banks actively exposing Open Finance APIs. Top-10 bank embedding rates strongly correlate with live rates.*



**Use the number of banks marked as 'Live/Onboarded/Participant' in the official Open Banking/Finance platform or regulatory ecosystem directory as the standard. It is recommended to define 'embedding' using both the SME ROI module and open data capabilities to avoid relying solely on weak indicators like 'having an app'.*

(2) Target Persona Typologies

The Digital Pioneers
BAHRAIN & UAE

- **Customer Base:** Tech-native SMEs, cross-border trade firms, and premium wealth segments.
- **Bank Focus:** Highly competitive; prioritizing high-net-worth services and corporate ecosystem integration.
- **Rigid Demand:** Strong appetite for Open Banking, API-led accounting integration, and bespoke digital experiences.

The Mass Market Giant
SAUDI ARABIA (KSA)

- **Customer Base:** The economic backbone—1.3M+ SMEs across energy, retail, and manufacturing.
- **Bank Focus:** Blended approach; balancing traditional mega-corporations with rapid SME digital onboarding.
- **Rigid Demand:** Transitioning from offline branches to mobile banking; massive unpenetrated demand for cash flow automation.

The Traditionalists
QATAR, KUWAIT, OMAN

- **Customer Base:** Government-linked entities, established family offices, and agriculture.

KEY CHALLENGES: THE $250B EXECUTION PARADOX

Planto

Unlocking the GCC market requires more than localization; Planto must systematically dismantle three severe barriers bridging our Hong Kong playbook to Middle Eastern realities.

The Transition Paradox

We have validated *the massive opportunity* on the previous slide. However, directly deploying the Hong Kong SaaS architecture will result in immediate operational failure.

> **To capture the ($250B SME gap)** across 168 highly traditional banks, we must navigate fragmented digital maturity and strict Islamic financial principles. The barriers are systemic, not just linguistic.

(APAThe Middle East Gulf region (GCC) **SME Financing Gap)**

NEED GAP

Product-Market Mismatch

Data Ref: 2.1M+ SMEs / 8% Credit

To capture the 2.1M SMEs and unblock the 8% credit stagnation, mere Arabic translation is insufficient. Our core engine lacks integration for mandatory regional specificities, such as **Sharia-compliant (Islamic Finance) filtering** and automated Zakat/VAT reporting.

Implication: Developing a B2B platform with zero end-user adoption.

TRUST GAP

Institutional Credibility Deficit

Data Ref: 168 Traditional Banks

Penetrating the 168 traditional GCC banks faces immense foreign-vendor friction. Tier-1 banks in KSA and UAE are notoriously risk-averse, strictly prioritizing established conglomerates or state-backed entities over foreign fintech startups.

Implication: 12-18 month enterprise sales cycles draining our cash runway.

COMPLIANCE GAP

Regulatory Fragmentation

Data Ref: 16% to 100% API Readiness

The GCC exhibits massive variance in digital maturity (e.g., Bahrain's 100% vs. UAE's 16% API readiness). Emerging Open Finance laws mandate strict data sovereignty, unlikely to be acceptable under local open-finance regimes; we will rely on regulated API / bank-led data access., the web-scraping tactics historically used in early-stage Hong Kong.

Implication: Heavy central bank penalties and permanent market exclusion.

STRATEGIC EXECUTION: FROM PILOT TO REGIONAL LEADERSHIP

Planto

"Execute a de-risked Middle East expansion by combining local user discovery, anchor bank alliances, and official sandbox pathways."

1 Pillars 1: Localized MVP via User Discovery

PHASE 1 FOCUS

- **Local User Discovery**
  Rebuild local research teams to replicate the "coffee chat" DNA
- **Agile MVP Focus**
  Prioritize and launch high-demand, high-impact modules like Cashflow Forecasting and Automated Accounting.
- **ROI-Driven Validation**
  Establish baseline metrics through real-world testing to prove ROI before scaling.

N Close the "Need Gap"

2 Pillars 2: Strategic Ecosystem Alliances

PHASE 2 FOCUS

- **Anchor Bank Leverage**
  Forge strategic alliances with local cloud giants or top-tier consultancies to establish instant credibility.
- **Joint Go-To-Market**
  Co-sell with institutional partners to penetrate the risk-averse Middle Eastern banking sector.
- **Reference Case Scaling**
  Deliver a successful anchor bank pilot to de-risk and accelerate GCC-wide adoption.

T Close the "Trust Gap"

3 Pillars 3: Sandbox-Led Compliance

ONGOING

- **Immediate Sandbox Entry**
  Apply early to UAE fintech sandboxes (Dubai/Abu Dhabi) for regulatory protection.
- **Compliant API Integration**
  Connect via official Open Finance APIs only — no unauthorized web scraping.
- **Data Sovereignty & Audits**
  Host data locally and use third-party audits to ensure institutional-grade security.

C Close the "Compliance Gap"

STRATEGIC EXTENSION: THE ISLAMIC FINANCE USP

Planto

Localization transcends Arabic translation. We hard-code Islamic Finance directly into Planto's engine, securing absolute cultural trust and transforming our MVP into a rigid local necessity.

SHARIA-COMPLIANT ENGINE THE 3 GUIDING PRINCIPLES

- **Zero Interest (Riba-Free)**
- **Profit Sharing (Mudarabah)**
- **Ethical Integrity (Halal)**

01 Automated Zakat Calculation

Repurposing cash-flow tools to automatically calculate the mandatory **2.5% Zakat (charity tax)** across SME accounts.

Solves a massive local accounting pain point.

02 Riba-Free Credit Matching

Recalibrating the AI engine to strictly filter out interest-bearing debt, matching SMEs exclusively with **Murabahah (Cost-plus)** products.

Secures endorsement from Tier-1 Islamic banks.

03 Halal ESG Audits & Certification

Using AI to flag prohibited (Haram) transactions, certified by independent **AAOIFI Shariah standards**.

Guarantees absolute regulatory governance.

EXECUTION TIMELINE: PILOT TO SCALE

Planto

"Establishing a repeatable 'ME Core' playbook (ROI-proven) before scaling into GenAI & stablecoin expansion curves."

P1: Validation (0–6M)

CRITICAL ACTIONS

- **Local deep-dive:** Interviews with bank stakeholders & SME end-users.
- **Anchor pilots:** Secure 1–2 banks for a focused 8–12 week ROI POC.
- **Compliance path:** Sandbox entry + local data hosting architecture.

KEY DELIVERABLES

- ME SME Edition MVP/PRD
- Signed POC scope & KPI set
- High-level data sovereignty map

DECISION GATE #1

Signed POC with clear ROI metrics and data access permission.

P2: Monetization (6–12M)

CRITICAL ACTIONS

- **SaaS conversion:** Transition POCs to recurring paid contracts.
- **GenAI light (None core):** Automated insights/summaries to boost engagement.
- **SOP hardening:** Standardize integration & implementation playbook.

KEY DELIVERABLES

- Commercial paid version live
- Co-branded bank success case
- Standardized SOP & legal docs

DECISION GATE #2

1+ POC converted to paid contract; demonstrated ROI for SMEs.

P3: Scale & Curves (1–3Y)

CRITICAL ACTIONS

- **GCC replicate:** Expand model to Qatar, Bahrain, and Saudi Arabia.
- **GenAI curve:** Launch RM/SME Copilot (high-margin upsell).
- **Stablecoin rails:** Pilot bank-led cross-border settlement solutions.

KEY DELIVERABLES

- Multi-bank GTM playbook
- Tiered SME module bundle
- Cross-border pilot framework

LONG-TERM SUCCESS

Scaling NRR without linear delivery cost; innovation layer dominance.

Growth Options Explain： GenAI / Stablecoin—not main line, but incremental growth engine in P3

The launch and implementation of the growth curve are based on the premise that the core business of SMEs in the Middle East will achieve stable profitability and replicable delivery, avoid resource dispersion, and ensure the success rate of the main line business.

GenAI

- **Core positioning:** Empower existing SME B2B solutions
- **Landing scene：**
  - Transform AI-generated risk insights into visual reports
  - Automatically generates customer profile
  - Automate reconciliation between banks and SMEs
- **Implementation principle:**

Reuse Planto's existing AI technology
Combine with local financial data in the Middle East

Stablecoin

- **Core positioning:** Focus on the rigid needs of SMEs in the Middle East for cross-border trade
- **Landing scenario:** Realize the rapid arrival of funds and reduce exchange costs
- **Implemention principle**
  - Cooperate with regulators and cooperative
  - Bank-dominate, Planto provides technical support
  - Lightweight pilot, verify feasibility and then gradually expand

GenAI and stablecoins are both value-added modules of core SME B2B solutions, which achieve the dual effect of "***core product lock + expansion curve revenue***" by improving the competitiveness and customer stickiness of core products, ultimately increasing average ***revenue per customer (ARPA)***.

FINANCIAL PROJECTIONS & RATIONALE

Achieving break-even by Year 2 is highly realistic. Our multi-tiered revenue model is explicitly validated by conservative market penetration metrics and the high willingness-to-pay of GCC Tier-1 banks.

**Internal estimation*

Revenue Model & Pricing Rationale

① Core SaaS Platform Fee — $200K-$500K

Annual B2B subscription charged per bank for the deployment of the core data aggregation engine.

Rationale: Validated by Tier-1 IT budgets. It is exponentially cheaper for banks to buy our plug-and-play SaaS than to risk multi-million-dollar in-house development failures.

② Data Insights / API Fee — $0.5-$2 / Call

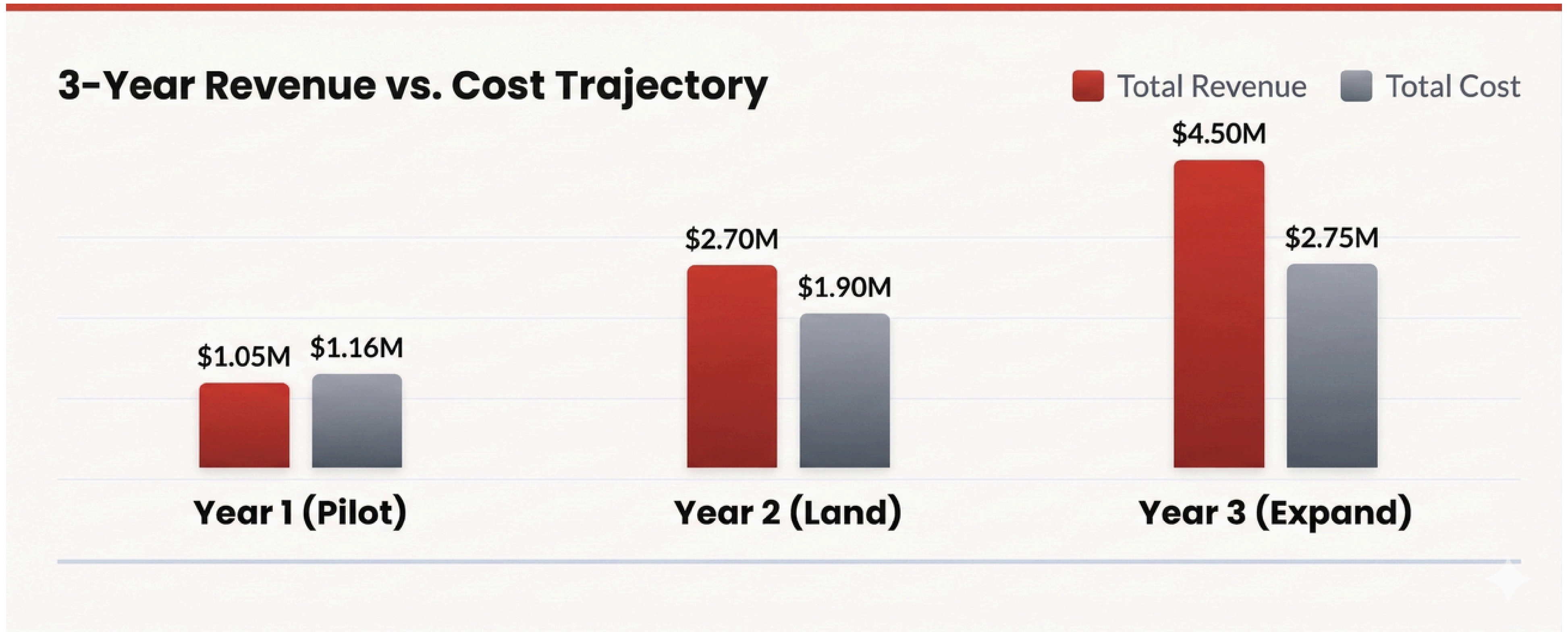
Usage-based billing deeply embedded in the Open Banking ecosystem, scaling with active SME adoption.

Rationale: Guaranteed volume growth driven by the CBUAE and SAMA regulatory mandates enforcing open data sharing.

③ Cross-Sell Affiliate — $50-$200 / Lead

CPA/CPS commissions upon successful conversion of SME financing products.

Rationale: Highly attractive to banks as our AI-driven targeting reduces their Customer Acquisition Cost (CAC) by ~40% vs. industry standards.



Periods	Y1	Y2	Y3
Banks Contracted	2	5	8
Projected ARR	$1.0M	$2.5M	$4.0M
Net Margin	Negative	Break-even	Positive

PROJECTION RATIONALE

- **Market Capture (Targeting 8 Banks):** Capturing 8 banks by Y3 represents only **~4.7% penetration** of the 168 GCC banks—a highly conservative estimation.
- **Y2 Break-even Logic:** Upfront implementation fees cover early setup costs. As recurring SaaS ARR and API usage compound, the asset-light model rapidly scales margins.
- **Gross Margin (~75%):** Sustained by reusing the core aggregation technology already perfected in Hong Kong, minimizing R&D burn.

KEY RISKS & MITIGATION STRATEGIES

To safeguard Planto's Middle East pivot, we proactively isolate and neutralize compliance, cultural, and liquidity risks through a disciplined execution model.

Regulatory & Compliance

Data Audit & Privacy Violations

Deploying unauthorized data scraping could violate strict Middle Eastern Open Finance frameworks, resulting in severe penalties.

MITIGATION PLAN

- **Regulatory Sandbox:** Secure operations by entering official CBUAE/SAMA Fintech sandboxes immediately.
- **Local Data Hosting:** Ensure absolute data sovereignty by storing all financial data on localized servers.
- **3rd-Party Audits:** Commission independent security audits to build Tier-1 bank trust.

Market & Cultural Mismatch

"Copy-Paste" Failure

Directly porting the HK software architecture without adapting to Arab business culture and Islamic finance rules will yield zero adoption.

MITIGATION PLAN

- **Grassroots Discovery:** Conduct intensive field interviews with local SMEs to map real friction points.
- **Rigid-Demand MVP:** Launch only critical modules first (Cash Flow Forecasting & Recon).
- **Islamic Finance Alignment:** Embed Sharia-compliant logic (e.g., automated Zakat calculation).

Liquidity & Cash Flow

Capital Burn Rate

Prolonged enterprise sales cycles (12-18 months) in the Middle Eastern B2B banking sector threaten to drain Planto's operational runway.

MITIGATION PLAN

- **Asset-Light Pilots:** Avoid massive upfront hires; utilize lean technical teams for initial proofs of concept.
- **Staggered Milestones:** Structure contracts for early cash flow (POC fees → Upfront Implementation fees).
- **Controlled Pace:** Cap scaling efforts until the first anchor bank proves the ROI loop.

Strategic Stance: Risk management is our primary operational directive. By treating regulatory compliance and local alignment as competitive moats rather than hurdles, Planto ensures a self-funding global expansion.

Appendix

Revenue Line (收入线)	Pricing Model (模式)	Pricing Assumption (ACV)	Rationale (依据)
① SaaS Platform Fee (Core)	Annual subscription per bank	**USD 200K–500K** / bank / year	B2B Enterprise FinTech benchmark (ACV > 100K). GCC Tier-1 banks have sufficient budget for premium pricing.
② Data Insights / API Fee	Per API call / Per active SME user	**USD 0.5–2 / Call** or USD 5–15 / User / Month	Based on a16z B2B FinTech data. Usage-based billing is standard in Open Banking ecosystem.
③ Cross-sell / Affiliate	CPA / CPS on conversion	**USD 50–200** per successful lead	Adopted Planto's HK model. CAC is ~40% lower than banking benchmarks in select scenarios.

Item	Y1	Y2	Y3
Banks Contracted (Cumulative)	2	5	8
ARR (ACV × Number of Banks)	600K–1,000K	1,500K–2,500K	2,400K–4,000K
Other Revenue (API Calls + Affiliate Commission)	50K	200K	500K
Total Revenue	650K–1,050K	1,700K–2,700K	2,900K–4,500K
Gross Profit (75%)	490K–790K	1,275K–2,025K	2,175K–3,375K
Total Cost	1,160K	1,900K	2,750K
Net Profit	(670K)–(370K)	(625K)–125K	(575K)–625K
Net Profit Margin	Negative (Pilot Phase)	~Break-even	Positive

	Assumption	Value	Rationale/Logic
1	First Pilot Market	UAE (ADGM/DIFC)	Open Finance; 3 sandbox options
2	Banks Signed (Y1)	2 Tier-1 Banks (POC → Formal Contract)	Pilot → Land pace; refer to Planto HK experience
3	Banks Signed (Y2)	+3 New (UAE Expansion +Bahrain/KSA Entry)	Land→Expand
4	Cumulative Banks (Y3)	5-8 Total	UAE + KSA +Bahrain
5	Average ACV	USD 300K-500K (SaaS+Implementation Fee)	Enterprise B2B FinTech benchmark; GCC banks have ample budget
6	Net Revenue Retention (NRR)	110-120%	B2B SaaS benchmark;*ACV > 100K* churn ＜ 5%
7	Gross Margin	70-80%	FinTech SaaS standard;target ≥75% (Finro/Simon-Kucher)
8	SMEs Served Per Bank	Y1:1,000;Y3:5,00>	GCC SME base >2.1M; Tier-1 banks have large SME base
9	SME Digitalization IT Budget	7-11% of revenue for IT,5-10% to SME tools	Avasant/BCG;GCC bank C/I ratio≈32%